

After the first dispute outcome

Pre-arbitration and arbitration, scheme by scheme

When your first response doesn't settle a dispute, the case can move into a second cycle: pre-arbitration and, if needed, arbitration with the card scheme. This guide shows, for each scheme, who has to act at each stage and how long they have.

Three things to know

- ① **The next move depends on the scheme.** In most flows, the issuer decides whether a case goes to arbitration. In Visa Allocation (fraud and authorisation disputes), that decision is yours.
- ② **The windows are short.** Once the second cycle starts, the deadline to escalate to arbitration is 10 to 15 days.
- ③ **Arbitration has a cost.** The card scheme's ruling is final, and the losing party pays its fee (typically USD 400–800) on top of the disputed amount.

Key deadlines

20 days	for you to send us your evidence when a dispute arrives
30 days	for the issuer to respond to the evidence we submit
10 or 15 days	to decide on arbitration: 10 for Visa and Discover / Diners, 15 for Mastercard

At a glance

The same stages go by different names in each scheme. This is what each one is called, and who decides whether the case goes to arbitration.

Stage	Visa Collaboration and Discover / Diners Visa 12.x and 13.x	Mastercard All reason codes	Visa Allocation Visa 10.x and 11.x
The issuer opens the dispute	Dispute	First chargeback	Dispute
We respond with your evidence You have 20 days	Dispute response	Second presentment	Pre-arbitration
The issuer rejects our evidence It has 30 days to review	Pre-arbitration	Pre-arbitration	Pre-arbitration response
We challenge the rejection	Pre-arbitration response	Pre-arbitration response	<i>No such stage</i>
Who decides on arbitration	Issuer	Issuer	You and Checkout
Time to decide	10 days after our pre-arbitration response	15 days after our pre-arbitration response	10 days after the issuer's pre-arbitration response

American Express works differently: it is both the card network and the issuer, so there is no pre-arbitration or arbitration stage. Amex's decision is final.

Good to know

- **Missing a deadline closes the case against whoever missed it.** If we don't hear from you in time, the chargeback stands.
- **Arbitration is final.** The card scheme's ruling is binding, and the losing party pays the arbitration fee (typically USD 400–800).
- **Weigh the cost before escalating.** For a low-value dispute, accepting liability can cost less than losing at arbitration.
- **Dates can change.** Schemes update their rules from time to time. We always confirm the exact deadlines on a live case.

Visa Collaboration and Discover / Diners

Visa processing-error (12.x) and consumer (13.x) disputes, and all Discover / Diners Club disputes · the issuer decides on arbitration

- 1

Initial chargeback

Dispute

The cardholder's issuing bank raises the dispute.
- 2

Our response

Dispute response

We challenge the dispute with your evidence. You have 20 days to send it to us.
- 3

Issuer rejection

Pre-arbitration

The issuer has 30 days to review. If it rejects our evidence, it raises a pre-arbitration.
- 4

Formal rebuttal

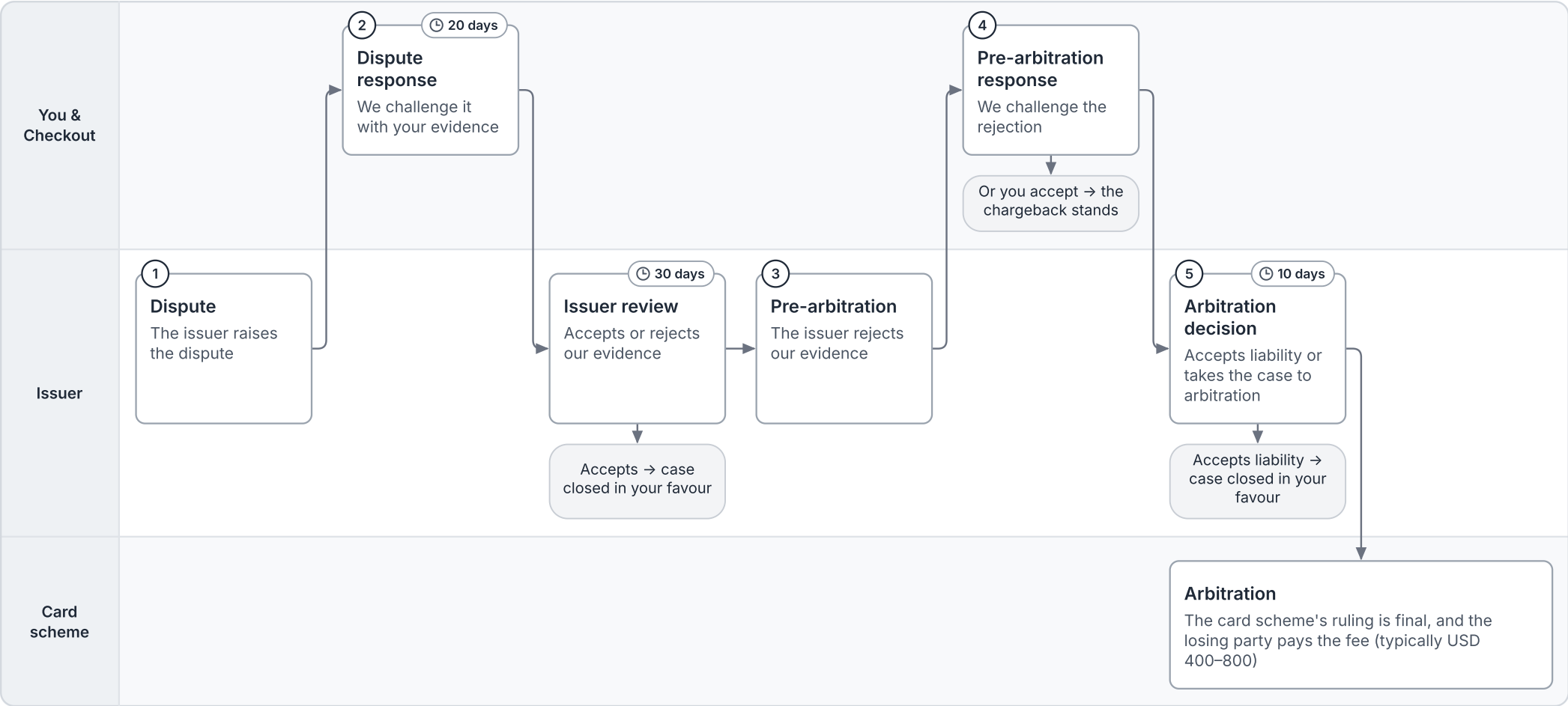
Pre-arbitration response

We formally challenge the rejection. You can also choose to accept the chargeback at this point.
- 5

Final resolution

Arbitration

The issuer has 10 days to accept liability or take the case to arbitration, where the losing party pays a fee (typically USD 400–800).



Mastercard

All reason codes · the issuer decides on arbitration

- 1

Initial chargeback

First chargeback

The cardholder's issuing bank raises the dispute.
- 2

Our response

Second presentment

We challenge the dispute with your evidence. You have 20 days to send it to us.
- 3

Issuer rejection

Pre-arbitration

The issuer has 30 days to review. If it rejects our evidence, it raises a pre-arbitration.
- 4

Formal rebuttal

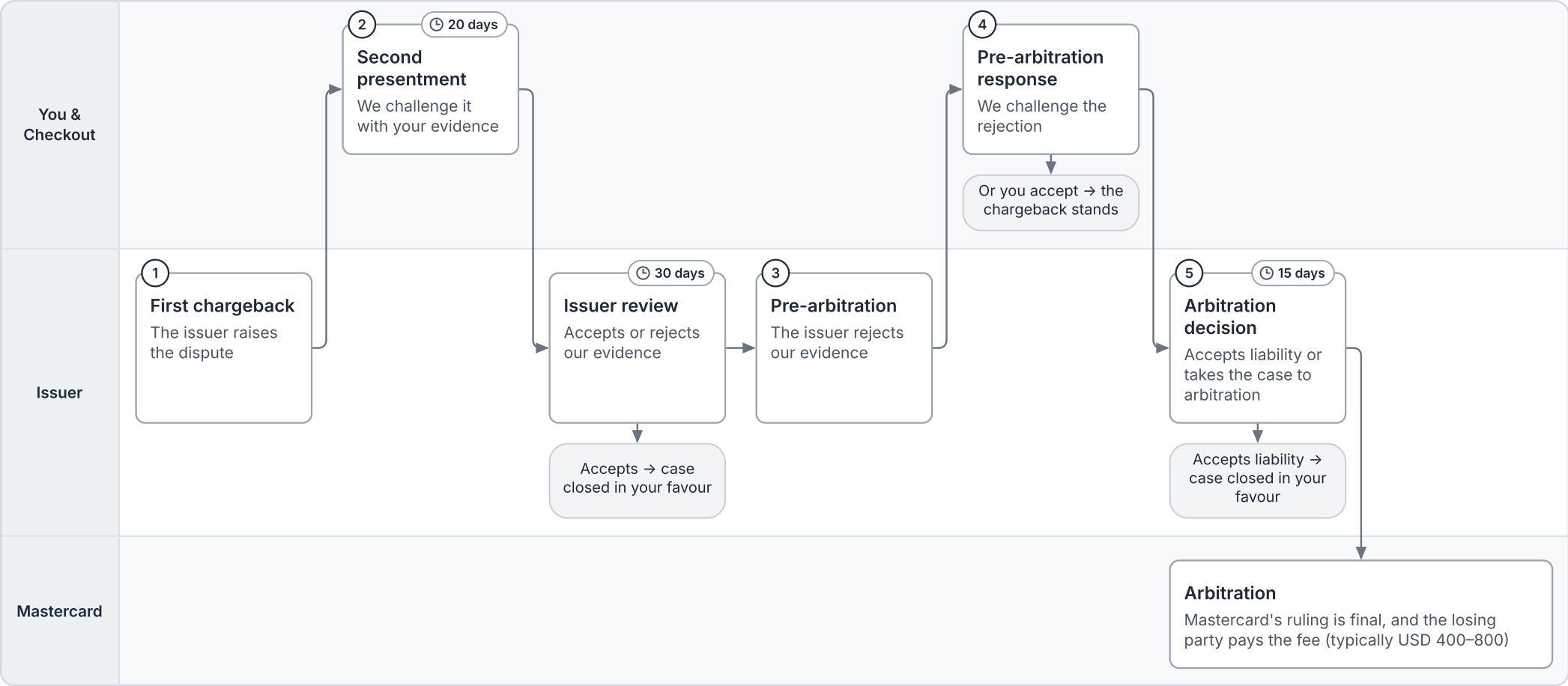
Pre-arbitration response

We formally challenge the rejection. You can also choose to accept the chargeback at this point.
- 5

Final resolution

Arbitration

The issuer has 15 days to accept liability or take the case to arbitration with Mastercard, where the losing party pays a fee (typically USD 400–800).



Visa Allocation

Fraud (10.x) and authorisation (11.x) disputes · you decide on arbitration, not the issuer

① Initial chargeback

Dispute

The cardholder's issuing bank raises a fraud or authorisation dispute.

② Our response

Pre-arbitration

We challenge the dispute with your evidence by raising a pre-arbitration. You have 20 days to send it to us.

③ Issuer rejection

Pre-arbitration response

The issuer has 30 days to review. If it rejects our evidence, it sends a pre-arbitration response.

④ Final resolution

Arbitration

You decide: accept liability, or take the case to arbitration with Visa, where the losing party pays a fee (typically USD 400–800). We have 10 days to file, so please tell us quickly.

